23,421 events · 156 countries · 23 years

Who Erodes Democracy?

Actor-Level Evidence from a Two-Part Model of Authoritarian Behavior

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When we talk about democratic backsliding, we picture a strongman.

But what if the real story is about the institutions around them?

23,421	156	23	1
coded events	countries	years (2000–2023)	question

Research Questions

PRIMARY QUESTION

Do authoritarian actions by specific political actors independently predict declines in democratic quality?

SUB-QUESTION

Does the onset of authoritarian behavior matter more than its escalation?

Extensive margin (onset) vs. intensive margin (volume) as predictors of V-Dem polyarchy decline

Data

DEED v7 + V-Dem v14 | Electoral democracies only

DEED v7

Democratic Erosion Event Dataset

23,421 hand-coded events

156 countries

2000–2023 time span

Actors coded at 54 individual types
Events: Precursors, Symptoms, Resistance, Destabilizing

V-Dem v14

Varieties of Democracy

Polyarchy Index

Continuous 0–1 scale measuring electoral democracy quality (contestation + participation)

Regimes of the World

Used for sample restriction: only countries that are or have ever been electoral democracies

Electoral democracies: democratic enough to erode, vulnerable enough to decline

The Two-Part Model

A new framework for analyzing democratic erosion

For each actor in each country-year:

1 Extensive Margin (Onset)

Did this actor engage in ANY authoritarian action? (Yes / No)

2 Intensive Margin (Escalation)

HOW MANY authoritarian actions, conditional on being active?

Model Specification

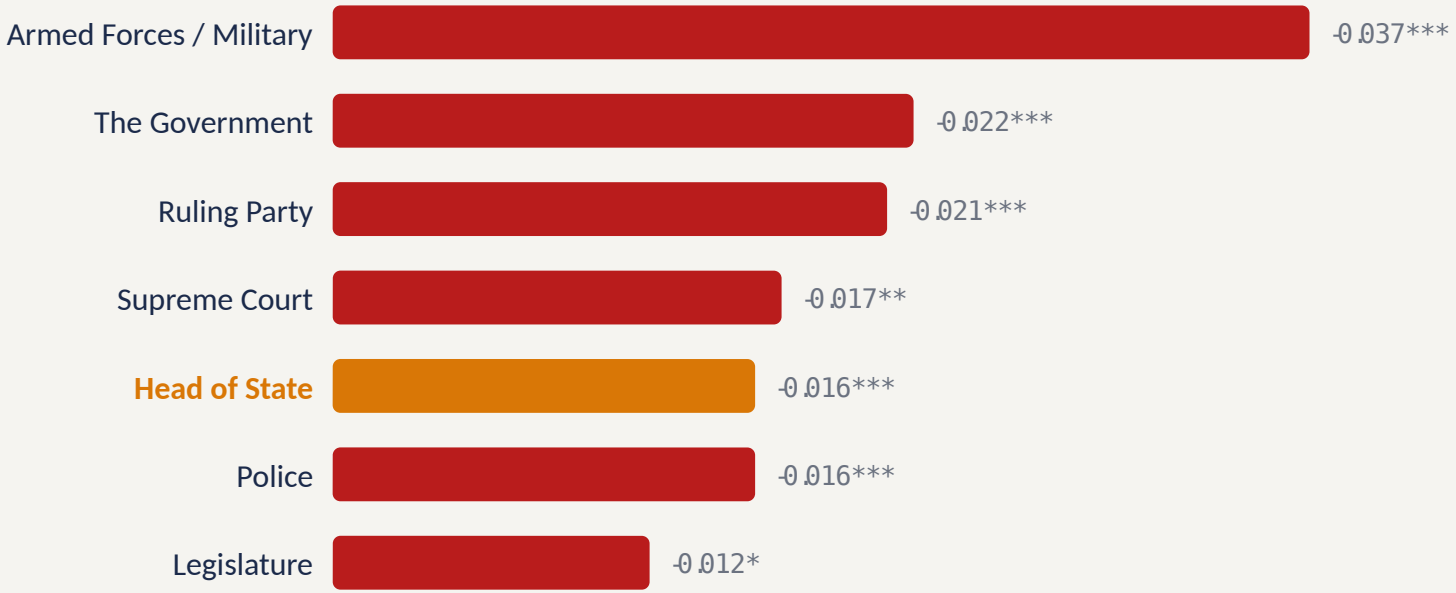
$$\text{Polyarchy}(t) = \text{Sum}\ [B(\text{ext}) \times 1(\text{active}) + B(\text{int}) \times \text{count}] + \text{country FE} + \text{year FE}$$

- Country fixed effects absorb all time-invariant country differences
- Year fixed effects control for global trends in democracy
- All predictors lagged one year to address simultaneity
- Both margins included simultaneously for each actor

Framework from the trade/conflict literature (Kim, Londregan & Ratkovic 2019), applied here for the first time to democratic backsliding.

Who Hurts Democracy?

Disaggregated results | Lagged 1 year | Extensive margin (onset)



The head of state is NOT the largest coefficient — the military is. Democratic backsliding is a multi-institutional process.

Who Protects Democracy?

Actors associated with democratic resilience | Positive coefficients

Civil Society Organizations

+0.033 extensive ($p < 0.05$)

+0.027 intensive ($p < 0.01$)

When CSOs mobilize, democracy is stronger the following year. Sustained engagement—not just occasional protest—predicts resilience.

Foreign Countries

+0.027 extensive ($p < 0.05$)

+0.042 intensive ($p < 0.01$)

International engagement—especially sustained attention, not one-off interventions—is associated with higher democratic quality.

These are the only institutional categories consistently associated with democratic resilience.

From Actors to Institutions

Aggregated model as robustness check

Why aggregate 54 actor types into 7 institutional categories?

Reduce Noise

54 individual actors create sparse columns. Pooling related actors yields more stable estimates.

Test Robustness

If the same institutional domains remain significant after pooling, the effects are genuine.

Match Theory

The literature identifies institutional domains—executive, military, judiciary—not specific officeholders.

The 7 Institutional Categories

1. Executive & Gov. Leadership
2. Military & Law Enforcement
3. Judiciary
4. Legislative Bodies
5. Civil Society & Advocacy
6. Media & Information
7. Foreign & International

The Institutional Drivers of Democratic Decline

Lagged grouped model (t−1) | Country + year FE | N = 1,462

Institutional Category	Extensive (Onset)	Intensive (Escalation)	Key Insight
Executive & Gov. Leadership	−0.0202***	−0.0103***	*Both margins significant*
Military & Law Enforcement	−0.0222***	−0.0103***	*Strongest onset signal*
Judiciary	−0.0122**	−0.0048	*Onset matters, not escalation*
Legislative Bodies	−0.0042	−0.0068**	*Escalation matters, not onset*
Civil Society & Advocacy	−0.0014	+0.0084*	*Sustained engagement helps*
Media & Information	−0.0102	−0.0068	*Not significant*
Foreign & International	+0.0198*	+0.0331***	*International attention works*

*** p < 0.01 ** p < 0.05 * p < 0.1

Red = decline **Orange** = mixed **Green** = resilience **Gray** = not significant

Onset Matters More Than Escalation

The extensive margin is generally a stronger predictor

Onset dominates for:

Military & Law Enforcement	−0.022***
Executive & Gov. Leadership	−0.020***
Judiciary	−0.012**

Escalation dominates for:

Legislative Bodies	−0.007**
Foreign & International	+0.033***
Civil Society & Advocacy	+0.008*

The critical early-warning signal:

It's not how many authoritarian actions the military takes —
it's that the military started taking them at all.

Implications: Detecting the Threat

What my findings mean for monitoring democratic health

Redesigning Early-Warning Systems

Current monitoring frameworks—Freedom House, V-Dem, the EU—track executive behavior as the primary indicator. My findings suggest a different approach:

- Monitor which NEW institutions enter the authoritarian space
- Military onset is the single strongest warning signal (−0.022***)
- Judicial activation matters more than judicial volume (−0.012**)
- Track onset, not just escalation—the first action is the red flag

A Diagnostic Tool for Today

This framework can be applied to any country currently experiencing backsliding:

1. Identify which institutional actors are engaging in authoritarian behavior
2. Classify each as onset (new entrant) or escalation (already active)
3. Prioritize the onset actors—they carry the strongest predictive signal
4. Map the multi-institutional threat landscape, not just executive actions

As of 2023, more countries are autocratizing than at any point since 2000 (V-Dem 2024). Better monitoring tools are urgent.

Implications: Building Resilience

What my findings mean for protecting democracy

Invest in Civil Society

+0.008* intensive margin

The only institutional category consistently associated with democratic resilience. Sustained civic engagement—not one-off protests—predicts higher democratic quality the following year.

Policy: Fund and protect civic organizations. NGO restrictions and protest bans remove democracy's immune system.

Sustain International Engagement

+0.033*** intensive margin

International engagement shows the strongest positive coefficient in the entire grouped model. But the pattern is revealing:

One-off interventions (extensive): +0.020*
Weak effect, marginally significant

Sustained attention (intensive): +0.033***
Strong effect, highly significant

Policy: Continuous international scrutiny works. Sanctions that expire, statements of concern that fade—those don't move the needle.

Limitations & Future Work

Limitations

- Lagged specification addresses timing but does not establish causality
- DEED relies on media coverage, which varies systematically by country
- Positive terrorist coefficients are selection artifacts (excluded from grouped model)
- "Ever electoral democracy" sample is deliberately broad

Future Directions

- Causal identification strategies (IV, regression discontinuity)
- Subnational analysis: does backsliding start in specific regions?
- Extending the time series backward and forward
- Interaction effects between actor categories

Democratic backsliding is a multi-institutional process.

The onset of authoritarian behavior by new actors is the strongest warning signal we have.

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